

BURNING FURY Tankers burnt in a protest after a grenade struck Meitei land, Bishnupur, Manipur, Apr. 7

PTI

▶ MANIPUR

A TRIANGLE OF FLAMING LINES

Fragile equilibrium tips over after a lethal rocket attack, as Manipur's ethnic cauldron pulls in even the Naga side

By **Hrijoy Das Kanungo**

IMMUNITY IS GRANTED TO NO ONE IN MANIPUR. Not even to those in uniform. Before dawn on April 7, two projectiles arced over the hills of Bishnupur. General purpose lethality was writ all over their flight path. After all, the village on that side of Manipur's infamous ethnic border, Tronglaobi, was Meitei. And the nearby hill slopes? Kuki-Zo territory.

One hit the home of a BSF jawan, out on duty in Bihar. His five-year-old son and five-month-old daughter were killed in their sleep; his mother was left gravely injured. By morning, the Imphal valley was on the streets, in large congregations of moving anger, burning tyres, even storming a CRPF post. Soon, three more Meiteis lay dead in retaliatory paramilitary fire near Gelmol.

The brittle calm that had held since chief minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh's swearing-in on February 4 had collapsed in a morning. Between April 7-27, Manipur unspooled some more. A total of 11 lay dead, including the two in Bishnupur and a seven-year-old internally displaced girl found dead on April 6. Vehicles burned on national highways, security personnel were frisked by civilians, and a serving Manipur police constable was arrested for stoning his colleagues. A seven-day women-led shutdown paralysed the valley, joined by Kuki and Naga shutdowns in the hills.

The last one spoke of a disturbing new element to the three-year-old conflict. A pre-dawn assault on Mulam Kuki village and an ambush along NH-202 that killed a retired Naga Regiment soldier showed that the wound first opened on May 3, 2023, has not closed. Instead, it had split along a new edge.

ADMIN ON THE BACKFOOT

By installing Khemchand, a moderate Meitei, the BJP meant to soothe the air after N. Biren Singh's allegedly partisan regime. A fresh face could perhaps buy time before assembly polls due in early 2027. The cabinet was engineered for inclusion: Nemcha Kipgen, a Kuki, and Losii Dikho, a Naga, were sworn in as deputy CMs. But the only thing that seems to have become more inclusive thereafter is the violence. The 2023 conflict was basically a Meitei-Kuki affair. The Naga hills mostly stayed out. That